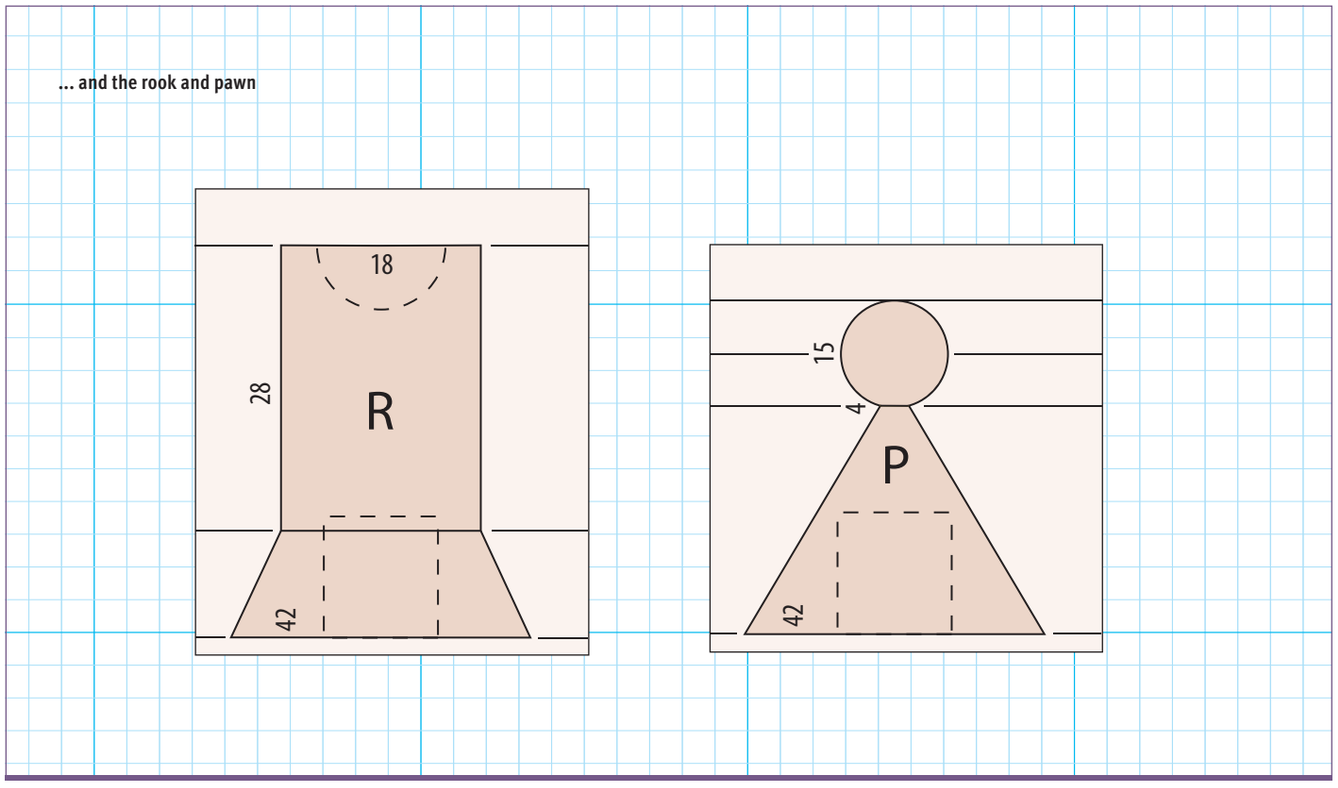

Making the men, except the knights

I decided to lead my set although this is optional. Except for the knights, the holes for the leading have to be bored before the men are turned. If the reverse were attempted, the men's turned finished surfaces are likely to be damaged by the secure gripping needed.

In order to finish-turn their tops, the men's workpieces had to be held by gripping them using the earlier-bored leading hole. I used a homemade large diameter screw chuck.

The sequence of operations I used for the men, except the knights, was:

1. Turn a cylindrical workpiece for each man. I turned them to about 46mm diameter and each to a length about 6mm longer than its finished height.
2. Chuck each workpiece by its top end in a scroll chuck. Cut the workpiece's right-hand end slightly concave with a skew's long point. Bore the leading hole. The hole diameter has to be sized so that the workpiece can be screwed both on and off the screw chuck's screw.
3. The bishops workpieces were turned more carefully to their finished length and 44.5mm diameter. After boring the 16mm leading hole as above, I cut the slot in each bishop with a tablesaw using the jig shown here. This jig contained a vertical hole of 1¾in diameter, and this diameter could be squeezed to securely grip a bishop workpiece.

My homemade screw chuck. The threaded section is 5/8in BSW. The diameter of the drill used to bore the leading hole is 16mm – this allows a workpiece to be screwed on and off without too much difficulty because the chuck's thread only just bites into the surface of the bored hole

A blank roughed to about 46mm diameter. The three workpieces will be separated by cutting through the small-diameter sections with a bandsaw or hand saw

Cutting the right-hand end of a king's workpiece. A skew's long point is used to produce a slightly concave surface. The workpiece has been chucked by its top end in a scroll chuck. One way to chuck a workpiece truly axially: chuck the workpiece fairly firmly but not tightly; turn on the lathe; locate the blade of a skew flat on the toolrest and beneath the rotating workpiece; then gradually lever the workpiece until it's running true. Stop the lathe and tighten the chuck

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